

Ethical models: DPIA & IAMA

Jeffrey Gerrits - Master of Applied Data Science UOS3 - 25-02-2026

This text compares two ethical models used in the context of data science: the Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) and the Impact Assessment Mensenrechten en Algoritmes (IAMA). Both models aim to identify and mitigate risks related to data-driven systems.

A Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) is part of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). It is a structured process that is required when data processing is likely to result in high risks to rights and freedoms of individuals (Rijksoverheid, 2025). The primary purpose of a DPIA is to assess privacy risks before processing begins and to define measures that mitigate those risks. It focuses on personal data and checks whether the data processing is lawful, necessary, and proportionate. It also looks at what measures are in place to protect people's data. In practice, a DPIA mainly helps organizations show that they follow data protection rules, such as collecting only the data they really need and using it only for a clear and specific purpose.

The IAMA is a broader ethical assessment framework designed to evaluate the societal and human rights impact of algorithmic systems (Rijksoverheid, 2026). Unlike a DPIA, which is grounded in data protection law, IAMA extends beyond privacy to include issues such as discrimination, autonomy, transparency and fairness. It typically requires identifying stakeholders, mapping potential harms, assessing risks to fundamental rights and considering mitigation strategies. IAMA is therefore less strictly legal and more normatively oriented toward responsible AI and public values (Ministerie van Binnenlandse Zaken en Koninkrijksrelaties, 2026).

Both models have similarities. They are preventive, meaning they are carried out before or during system development to reduce risks. Both follow a structured approach: identifying risks, assessing their impact, and defining measures to limit harm. In both cases, the goal is to protect people from negative consequences of AI systems.

The main difference lies in scope. A DPIA is legally required under the GDPR when personal data processing poses high privacy risks. It focuses specifically on lawful data use and privacy protection. IAMA, however, has a broader perspective. It looks beyond privacy and examines wider human rights and societal impacts, even when no personal data is processed.

Another difference is their focus. The DPIA concentrates on only the data-part of a system and whether it is handled correctly. IAMA looks at the overall technology itself and the effects of it, such as fairness, safety and inequality (Considerati, 2022).

Most suited for data ethics and personal reflection

In my opinion, the IAMA model is best suited for data ethics because it looks at the broader impact of AI systems on society. In an ideal situation, data ethics is not only about following the law, but also about fairness, transparency and social responsibility. IAMA helps to reflect on these wider effects.

Personally, I prefer this broader approach. At the same time, I fear that focusing on- and conducting an IAMA can require extra time and administrative work within a project. In practice, there is not always enough capacity for this. I would find it unfortunate if extensive procedures would slow down innovation too much. Therefore, a balance between ethical reflection and practical feasibility is important in my opinion.

References

Considerati. (2022). *DPIA versus IAMA, wat is de meerwaarde?* Opgehaald van Considerati: <https://www.considerati.com/nl/kennisbank/dpia-iama-wat-is-de-meerwaarde.html>

Ministerie van Binnenlandse Zaken en Koninkrijksrelaties. (2026). *Toelichtingsdocument IAMA*. Opgehaald van Ministerie van Binnenlandse Zaken en Koninkrijksrelaties: <https://open.overheid.nl/documenten/20d7e5c0-300c-4ff2-83b0-92deec241857/file>

Rijksoverheid. (2025, mei 1). *Data Protection Impact Assessment*. Opgehaald van Kenniscentrum voor beleid en regelgeving: <https://www.kcbr.nl/ontwikkelen-beleid-en-regelgeving/beleidskompas/verplichte-kwaliteitseisen/data-protection-impact-assessment>

Rijksoverheid. (2026). *Impact Assessment Mensenrechten en Algoritmes*. Opgehaald van Rijksoverheid.nl: <https://www.rijksoverheid.nl/documenten/rapporten/2026/02/16/impact-assessment-mensenrechten-en-algoritmes>